

VS.TALENT | DESIGN TALENT INTELLIGENCE

DESIGN CANDIDATES REPORT

FOOTWEAR & APPAREL DESIGN TALENT INTELLIGENCE

GLOBAL TALENT DATA • MARKET INSIGHT • HIRING ACTION

ORIGINAL COVER ART / AUGUST 2026

AUGUST 2026

369 global design candidates | +33 month-to-date

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01 EXECUTIVE OVERVIEW

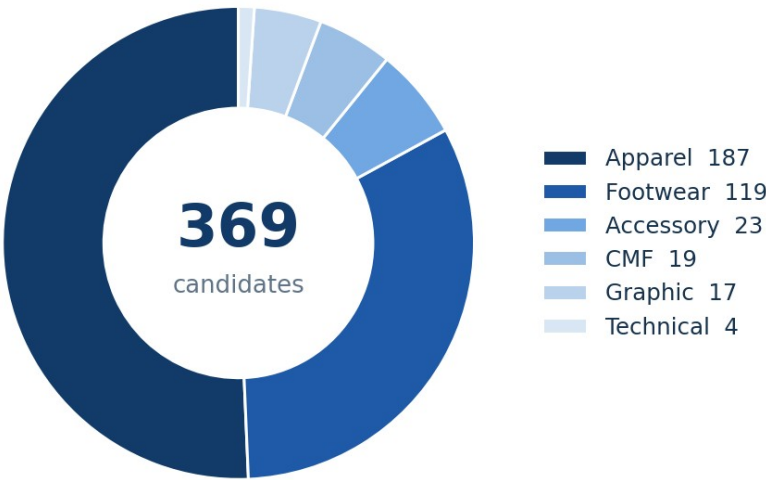
Executive Summary | AUGUST 2026 DASHBOARD

As of 27 August 2026, the VS.talent database covers 369 footwear and apparel design professionals who are recently open to opportunities - 33 more than the July snapshot, representing 9.8% growth. The August additions are weighted toward apparel design and strengthen the database across Sportstyle, Outdoor, Fashion and Luxury.

369 Global design talent TOTAL CANDIDATES	+33 Added by 27 August +9.8% VS JULY SNAPSHOT	66.1% Leading-brand experience 244 UNIQUE CANDIDATES	51.0% Cross-border preference 183 OF 359 ELIGIBLE
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Talent Structure

Functional Mix



Key Findings

- Apparel and footwear designers account for 82.9% of the database and remain the core talent supply.
- China and Japan received 147 and 120 destination selections respectively; among cross-border inflows alone, Japan leads narrowly with 101 selections versus China's 95.
- Because of a tie at rank 10, this issue displays 11 leading brands. Together they cover 244 unique candidates, or 66.1% of the database.
- The compensation analysis contains 107 valid records (29.0% coverage). The chart displays 99 records across eight countries and flags directional small-sample markets separately.

Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | Data cut-off: 27 August 2026 | Month-to-date snapshot

02 METHODOLOGY

Methodology & August Changes | DATA SCOPE AND COMPARABILITY

Scope & Definitions

- Sample: 369 footwear and apparel design professionals who are recently open to opportunities, spanning Apparel, Footwear, Accessory, Graphic, CMF and Technical Design.
- Brand, category and work-location fields are multi-response. A candidate may be counted under more than one brand or destination, so the corresponding percentages should not be added to 100%.
- Cross-border flows are calculated as current location to preferred work country. Same-country selections, Remote, Freelance, Hybrid and the broad Europe option are excluded; a consistent universe of 16 major country markets is used. Current-location data is eligible for 359 candidates.
- Monthly comparisons recalculate the July-end and 27 August master files using the same rules. The database added 33 candidates month-to-date, while preferred-location fields were updated for seven existing records.

What Changed in August (MTD)

Metric	July	Aug 27	Change
Total candidates	336	369	+33
Valid salary records	102	107	+5
adidas-experienced candidates	101	106	+5
Candidates selecting China	126	147	+21
Cross-border selections (location-based)	213	237	+24

Data Quality

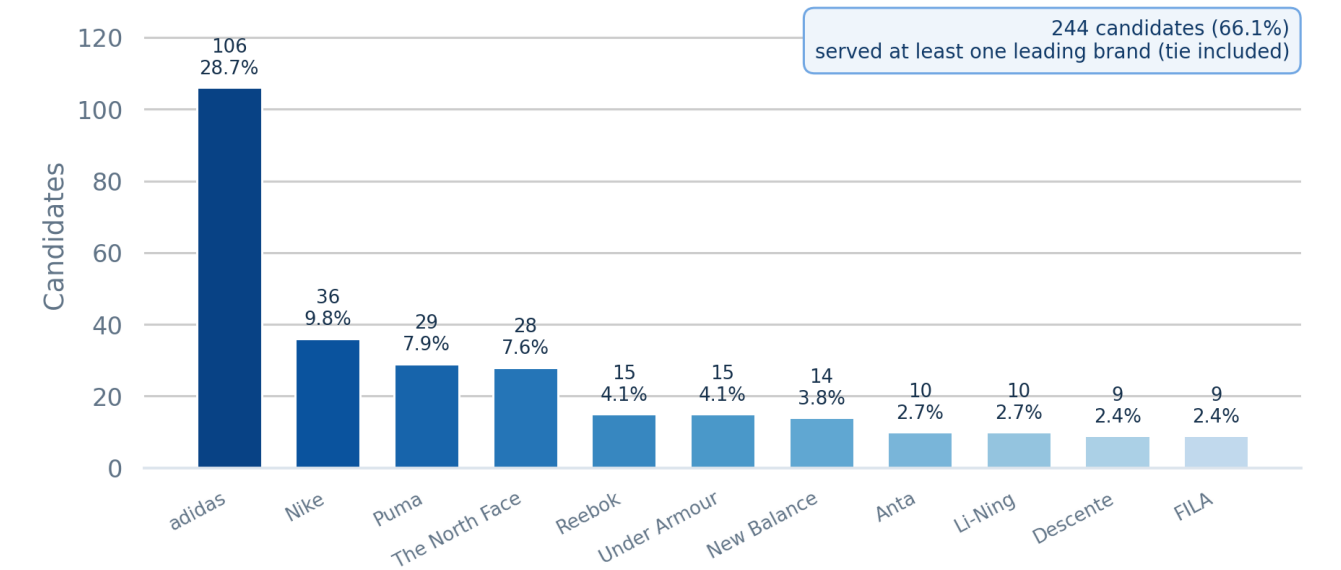
Data coverage Usable annual compensation is available for 107 records, or 29.0% of the database. The box plot shows 99 records across eight countries. All USD values are converted from the cleaned RMB field at RMB 7.20 per USD; the inconsistent source USD reference field is excluded. Category-field completeness is 95.7%, with 16 records still pending confirmation.

Cleaning standardised punctuation, brand capitalisation, apostrophe variants such as Arc'teryx, Sportstyle category spelling, Remote work terminology and location labels such as American to US. Italy, the UK, Japan and France are small-sample compensation markets and should be read directionally. The USD conversion is an analytical reporting rate rather than a historical transaction rate. All data is self-reported by candidates or recorded through VS.talent assignments; monthly changes reflect the composition of the database and are not estimates of the total global talent market.

03 DATA INSIGHT

Leading Brands Served by Candidates | BRAND EXPERIENCE

Leading Brands Served by Candidates



01 adidas remains the largest single-brand talent ecosystem

A total of 106 candidates have worked at adidas, representing 28.7% of the database and approximately 2.9 times the Nike count. August additions increased the adidas, Nike and Under Armour pools by five, three and three candidates respectively.

02 The tie at rank 10 is handled explicitly

Descente and FILA each account for nine candidates and share tenth place, so 11 leading brands are displayed. Together, the group covers 244 unique candidates, or 66.1% of the database.

03 Leading-brand experience matters, but it is not the only source

Another 125 candidates sit outside these 11 brands, primarily across specialist outdoor, luxury, fashion and regional players. They provide an important source of differentiated talent.

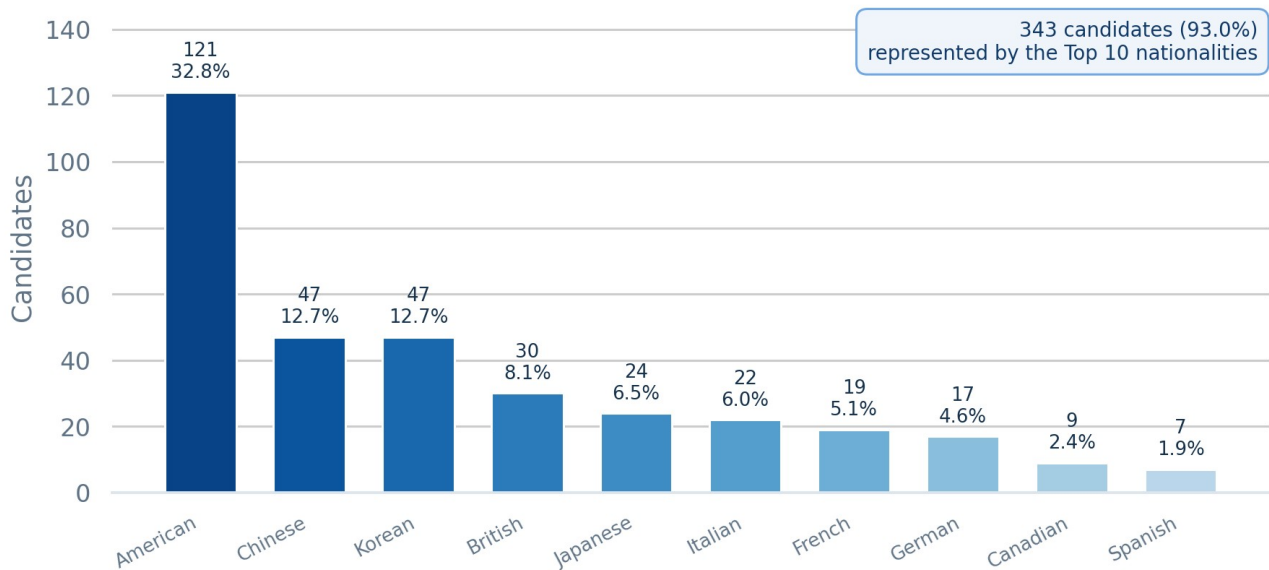
Implication for Employers Leading brands are an efficient starting point for talent mapping, but shortlists should not rely on brand recognition alone. Category depth, end-to-end product development, commercial execution and team fit still require separate assessment.

Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | Multi-response brand field | Tie at rank 10 retained | August 2026

04 DATA INSIGHT

Candidate Nationality Distribution | TOP 10 NATIONALITIES

Top 10 Nationalities



01 US talent extends its lead as the largest nationality group

The database contains 121 US candidates, representing 32.8%, including 13 August additions. The US group is now close in size to the combined 94 Chinese and Korean candidates.

02 The new cohort is more weighted toward Europe and the US

Of the 33 August additions, 13 are from the US, while Italy and China contribute five each. Compared with July’s more East Asia-weighted intake, August adds more fashion, luxury and sports backgrounds from Europe and the US.

03 Top 10 nationality coverage remains stable

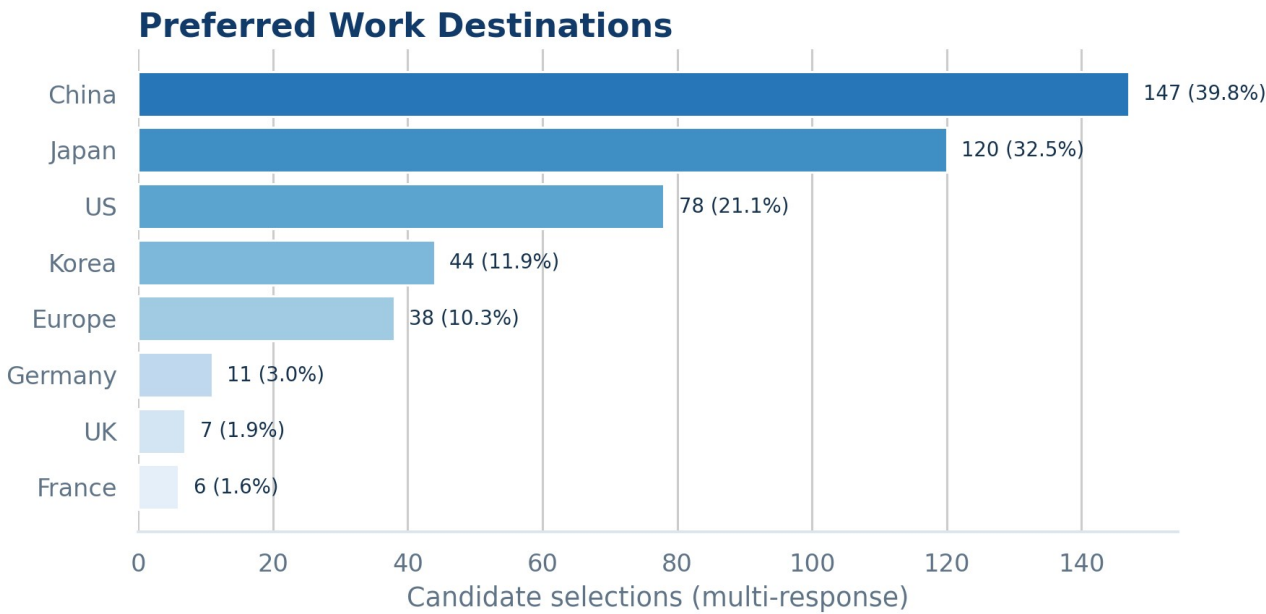
The ten leading nationalities account for 343 candidates, or 93.0%. The remaining 26 candidates span 15 nationalities and continue to broaden the cultural and market perspectives available to global teams.

Implication for Employers International hiring should balance creative diversity, relevance to the target market and practical mobility. Nationality can help structure a talent map, but it cannot replace assessment of category capability, consumer insight and organisational fit.

Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | One nationality per candidate | August 2026

05 DATA INSIGHT

Preferred Work Destinations | GEOGRAPHIC PREFERENCES



01 China remains the most frequently selected destination

China was selected by 147 candidates, or 39.8%, up by 21 from July. Eighteen of those additional selections came from the August cohort; the remainder reflect updates to existing records.

02 Japan remains second overall and leads cross-border inflow

Japan received 120 selections, representing 32.5%. After excluding candidates already based there, Japan records 101 cross-border selections, ahead of China's 95.

03 Three Asian markets form the principal geographic cluster

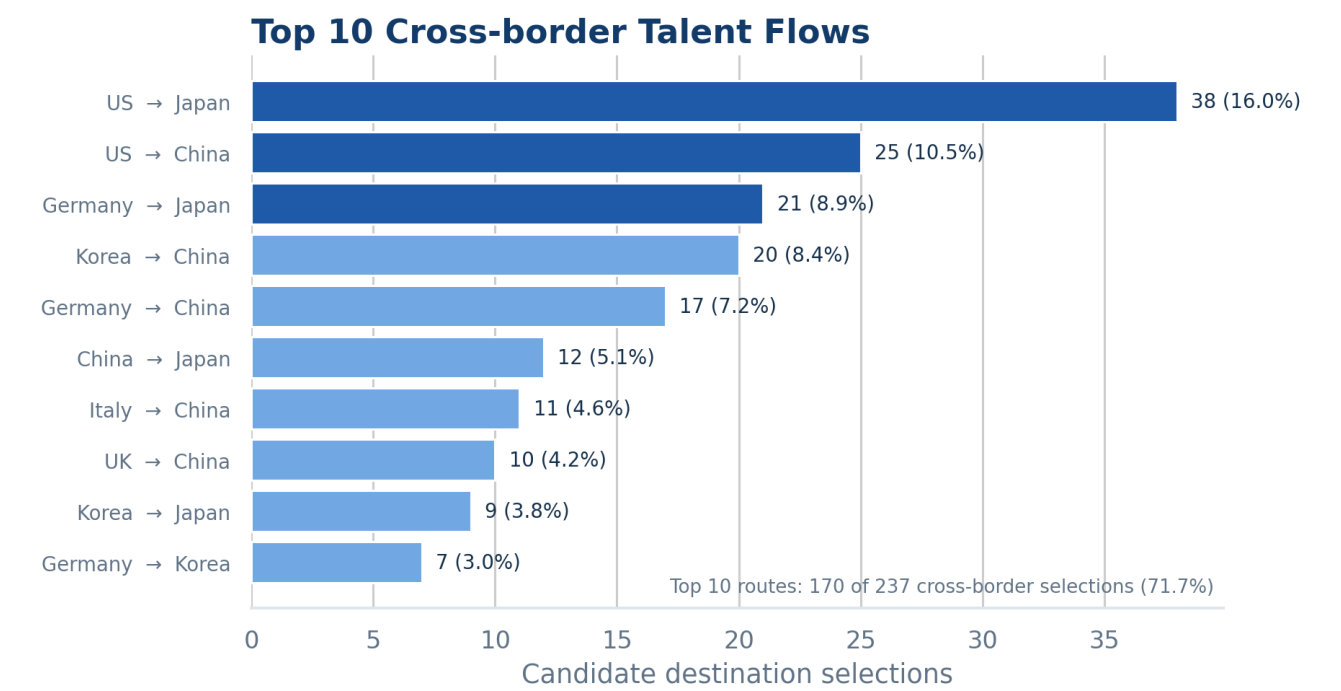
A total of 239 candidates selected at least one of China, Japan or Korea, representing 64.8%. The US and Europe still attracted 78 and 38 selections respectively, confirming that many candidates maintain multi-destination preferences.

Implication for Employers Recruiters should distinguish early between a candidate's first-choice destination, acceptable alternatives and flexible working preferences. Clarifying the true ranking reduces late-stage attrition caused by misaligned relocation expectations.

Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | Geographic selections only; Remote work, Freelance, Hybrid work and Overseas excluded | Multi-response | 27 August 2026

06 DATA INSIGHT

Cross-border Design Talent Flows | TOP 10 LOCATION-BASED FLOWS



01 Japan and China remain the two main inflow centres

Of 237 cross-border destination selections, Japan received 101 and China 95. Together, the two markets account for 82.7% of all cross-border selections.

02 The US and Germany are the primary origin markets

US to Japan ranks first with 38 selections, followed by US to China with 25. Germany to Japan and Germany to China contribute 21 and 17 respectively.

03 Mobility is widespread, but routes are highly concentrated

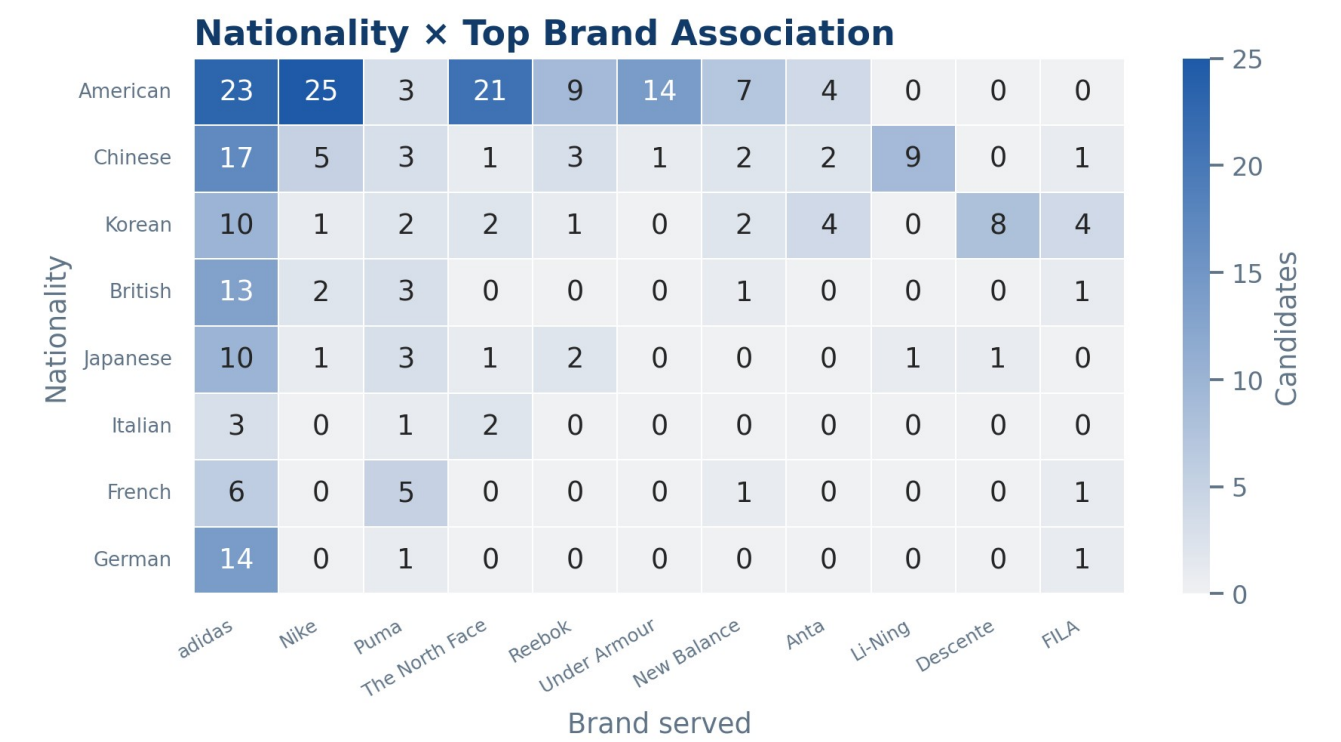
Among 359 candidates eligible under the 16-market current-location definition, 183 have at least one cross-border country preference, or 51.0%. The top ten routes account for 170 selections, or 71.7% of all flows.

Implication for Employers When hiring international talent into China or Japan, employers should build source-market-specific target lists and confirm visa, relocation, family and role-authority considerations from the first conversation. Interest in a market should not be mistaken for immediate relocation readiness.

Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | Origin = current location; destination = preferred country | Eligible origin records n=359 across 16 major markets | 27 August 2026

07 DATA INSIGHT

Nationality × Brand Association | TALENT-ECOSYSTEM HEAT MAP



01 US talent spans the broadest sports and outdoor brand mix

US candidates account for 25 at Nike, 23 at adidas and 21 at The North Face, as well as 14 at Under Armour.

02 adidas has the most internationally distributed talent base

adidas experience appears across all eight leading nationality groups, including 23 US, 17 Chinese, 14 German and 13 UK candidates, making it a strong ecosystem for cross-country talent mapping.

03 Asian brand experience shows stronger regional association

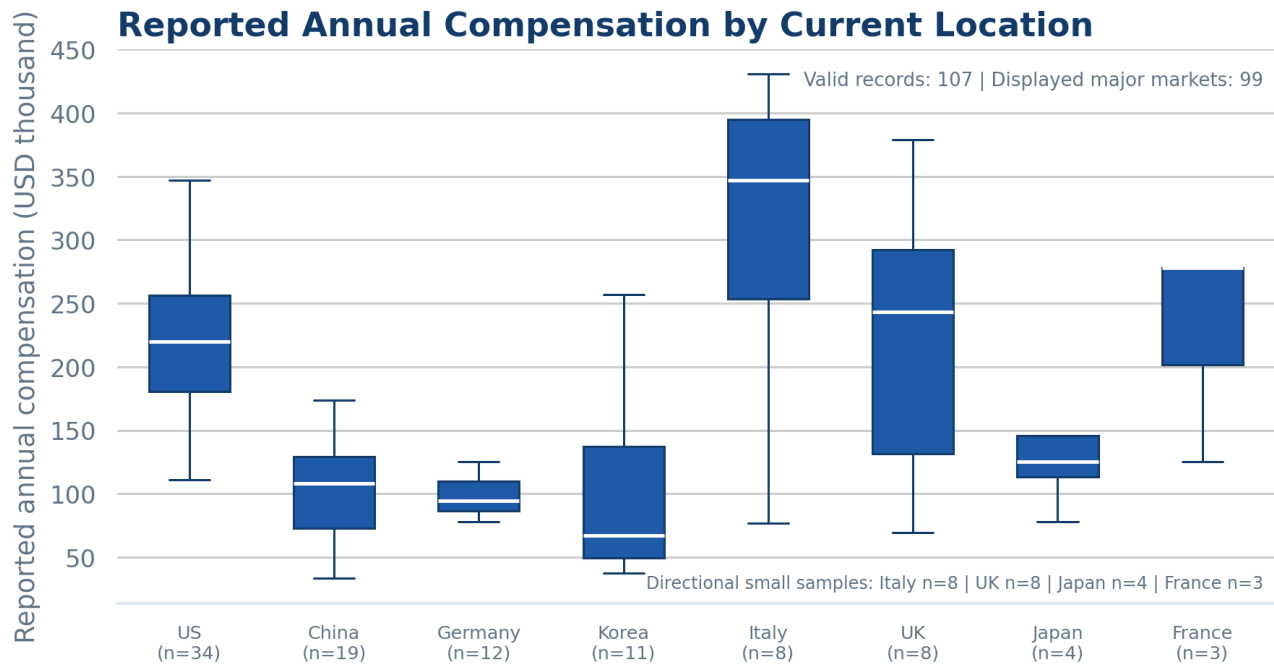
Nine Chinese candidates have worked at Li-Ning. Among Korean candidates, eight have Descente experience, while four each have worked at Anta and FILA.

Implication for Employers A talent map combining current market, nationality, brand and category is more effective than brand-only sourcing. It helps recruitment teams locate genuine talent clusters and prioritise candidates with the required category depth.

Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | Candidates may have served multiple brands | August 2026

08 DATA INSIGHT

Compensation by Current Location | USD ANNUAL PAY



01 The US has the highest median among larger-sample markets

Across 34 valid US records, the median is approximately USD 220K, above China at USD 108K, Germany at USD 94K and Korea at USD 67K.

02 Eight countries provide a broader geographic view

The chart now displays the US, China, Germany, Korea, Italy, the UK, Japan and France, covering 99 records in total. The remaining eight records come from markets with fewer than three observations.

03 Small-sample European and Japanese markets are directional

Italy and the UK each have eight records, Japan four and France three. Their higher or lower medians may be driven primarily by individual senior candidates and sample composition.

Implication for Employers International compensation budgets should compare like-for-like seniority, category and role scope rather than national medians alone. Bonus, relocation, visa, housing and career-development support should be assessed alongside reported compensation.

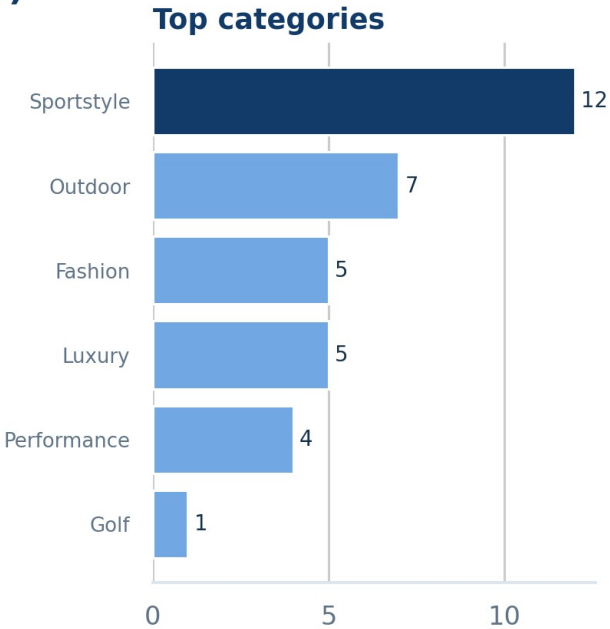
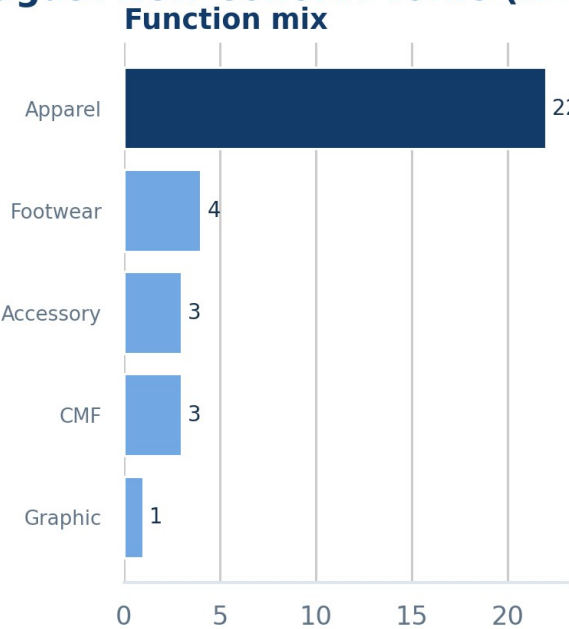
Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | Converted from cleaned RMB at RMB 7.20 per USD | Source USD reference field excluded | Valid n=107; displayed n=99 across 8 countries | Outliers hidden | 27 August 2026

09 MONTHLY COHORT

August New Cohort Profile | MONTH-TO-DATE

The database added 33 candidates by 27 August. Of these, 22 are apparel designers, representing 66.7%; 13 are from the US, while Italy and China contribute five each. Separating the new cohort from the full database provides a clearer view of the capabilities added this month.

August New Cohort Profile (n=33)



01 The intake is clearly weighted toward apparel

Twenty-two additions are apparel designers, or 66.7% of the new cohort, while only four are footwear designers. August's database growth is therefore not evenly distributed across functions.

02 Sportstyle is the leading new category

Twelve additions have Sportstyle experience, followed by Outdoor with seven and Fashion and Luxury with five each, strengthening sports-lifestyle, fashion and luxury coverage.

03 Flexible working preferences require a separate pathway

Eleven additions selected at least one of Freelance, Remote or Hybrid, representing 33.3%. Eight explicitly selected Freelance, although some are also open to China, Japan or the US.

Implication for Employers New talent should be segmented into three pathways: full-time relocation, project-first engagement and remote collaboration. A project can give selected international candidates a lower-risk way to understand the brand, validate mutual fit and potentially progress toward a longer-term relationship.

Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | New records added by 27 August: n=33 | Categories are multi-response; totals may exceed n=33

10 MARKET WATCH

From Full-time Hiring to Project-first | A TALENT CONVERSION PATH

Among the 33 candidates added by 27 August, 11 selected at least one of Freelance, Remote or Hybrid, representing 33.3%; eight explicitly selected Freelance. This does not suggest that international designers are broadly abandoning full-time roles. It indicates that some prefer to evaluate a brand, team and creative mandate through project work first.

For employers, a project-first model can address three practical needs: filling a critical capability before permanent headcount is confirmed; testing aesthetic alignment, pace and communication through real deliverables; and building trust and a body of work before cross-border relocation. This route is particularly useful for early-stage engagement with Creative Directors, Design Directors and scarce category specialists.

However, project work should not become an undefined probation period. Employers still need to specify deliverables, intellectual property, revision rounds, communication ownership, payment milestones and whether a permanent role may follow. Project-first becomes a genuine conversion tool only when the engagement boundaries are clear.

Implication for Employers

Employer Action	Why It Matters
Define the project objective	Put the collection direction, category, deliverables, timeline and review gates into the brief.
Separate consulting from employment	Clarify decision rights, working model, confidentiality and IP to avoid role-expectation gaps.
Set a conversion review point	If long-term cooperation is possible, schedule mutual feedback and a next-step decision at mid-project.
Keep one accountable coordinator	Assign one business or HR owner across design, legal, payment and cross-border communication.

Source: VS.talent market observation informed by August cohort data and active international design searches | August 2026

11 HIRING RECOMMENDATIONS

Hiring Recommendations | FROM DATA TO ACTION

This month's recommendations focus on five areas - talent sources, geographic mobility, engagement models, compensation comparability and data governance - to help employers convert talent intelligence into practical hiring action.

01 Start with leading brands, but retain an adjacent talent pool

The 11 leading brands cover 244 candidates, or 66.1%, while 125 come from specialist outdoor, luxury, fashion and regional brands. For each priority role, build both a core-brand pool and an adjacent-capability pool.

Suggested metrics: pool size, category coverage and interview conversion from outside the leading brands.

02 Use different source-market strategies for China and Japan

Japan received 101 cross-border selections and China 95. Japan can prioritise the US and Germany; China can prioritise the US, Korea, Germany, Italy and the UK, with the role proposition adapted to each source market.

Suggested metrics: international share of the shortlist, interview acceptance rate and source-market conversion.

03 Build separate full-time and project-first pathways

Set different entry criteria, assessment methods and contract templates for full-time relocation, project-first and remote talent. Where relocation readiness or permanent headcount is unresolved, use a clearly defined project brief to validate cooperation.

Suggested metrics: on-time project delivery, project renewal and conversion to a permanent relationship.

04 Compare compensation on like-for-like role scope

The 107 valid compensation records cover only 29.0% of the database, and the eight displayed markets do not have identical seniority structures. Budgets should also consider category, team size, bonus and relocation support.

Suggested metrics: comparable sample size by seniority, offer-budget variance and compensation-data completeness.

05 Introduce a monthly data-change audit

By 27 August, 33 candidates had been added and seven existing records updated. Each issue should separate new additions, field updates and methodology changes to avoid presenting database maintenance as a complete monthly market trend.

Suggested metrics: field completeness, duplicate rate, change-log coverage and pre-publication audit pass rate.

Key Recommendation The highest-priority next step is a dual-path talent funnel: one route for candidates ready for full-time relocation, and another for project-first or remote talent. The two paths should use different assessments, contracts and conversion metrics.

12 NEW TALENT SPOTLIGHT

Selected August Talent | ANONYMISED SHORTLIST

Ten profiles have been selected from the 33 August additions, spanning Footwear, Apparel, Accessory, Graphic and CMF. To reduce identification risk, exact brands are replaced with brand types, nationality is omitted and current location is grouped into broad regions. Full career history, portfolio, language capability and interview availability should be confirmed directly through VS.talent.

ID	Function	Brand Background	Category	Mobility Preference	Reported Comp.
AUG-01	Footwear	International Outdoor Footwear Brand	Outdoor	North America → China	USD 180–220K
AUG-02	Apparel	Global Outdoor Brand	Outdoor	Europe → Japan / Europe	USD 70–100K
AUG-03	Footwear	Global Sportswear Brand	Performance, Sportstyle	Asia → China / Japan	USD 100–140K
AUG-04	CMF	Global Sportswear Brand	Sportstyle	Europe → Europe / China	Not disclosed
AUG-05	Apparel	International Golf Brand	Golf	North America → China	Not disclosed
AUG-06	Apparel	Global Sportswear Brand	Sportstyle	North America → Japan / China / Flexible	USD 280–420K
AUG-07	Apparel	Global Outdoor Brand	Outdoor	Asia → China	Not disclosed
AUG-08	Graphic	Leading Chinese Sportswear Brand	Sportstyle	Asia → China	Not disclosed
AUG-09	Accessory	European Premium Sportswear Brand	Sportstyle	Europe → Japan / Flexible	Not disclosed
AUG-10	Apparel	Global Luxury Brand	Luxury	Europe → Europe / Flexible	Not disclosed

Reported Comp. is the candidate's self-reported annual compensation band in USD, converted at RMB 7.20 per USD; it is not expected compensation. 'Not disclosed' does not indicate that the candidate has no compensation requirement.

Privacy Exact brands have been replaced with brand types, nationality has been removed and current location is grouped into broad regions. Compensation bands and anonymous IDs are also used. Full profiles are available only to verified hiring clients and must not be used to identify individuals publicly without candidate authorisation.

13 CREATIVE & DESIGN OUTSOURCING

Creative & Design Outsourcing | FLEXIBLE GLOBAL DESIGN CAPABILITY

Drawing on its global design-talent network, VS.talent provides flexible and scalable creative and design outsourcing for footwear and apparel brands. Without expanding permanent headcount, employers can engage consultants and freelance designers with international brand experience for seasonal projects, priority categories or short-term capability gaps.

01 Seasonal Capsule & Key Look Seasonal capsules, thematic direction, key looks and the visual logic of a collection.	02 Footwear & Apparel Design Product design, range extension, design language and detailed product refinement.
03 Trend, Story & CMF Trend research, storytelling, colour, materials, graphics and resource-library development.	04 Global Creative Consultancy Creative direction, brand-DNA definition, team review and coordination of global design resources.

Engagement Process

01 Brief Define the brand, category, scope and deliverables	02 Match Select the right consultant or design team	03 Create Develop concepts and designs with milestone reviews	04 Deliver Finalise delivery, revisions and development support
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Where It Works Best

- A new brand or product line needs to establish a design direction quickly.
- The permanent team faces a capability gap during peak seasons, specialist-category work or international projects.
- The brand needs an international perspective but is not ready to add permanent headcount.
- A project is used to validate fit with an external designer before permanent hiring.

Engagement Outsourcing can be structured by project scope, working day or milestone. If the designer converts to permanent employment within one year, a fee credit may be arranged under the parties' service agreement.

14 ABOUT VS.TALENT

Connecting Global Design Talent with Brand Growth

VS.talent Consulting specialises in global footwear and apparel design recruitment across sportswear, outdoor, fashion, lifestyle and premium brands. Through executive search, talent intelligence and creative outsourcing, we help brands build internationally competitive design organisations.

Global Design Search	Creative Director, Head of Design, Design Director and senior Footwear / Apparel / Graphic / Accessory / CMF search.
Talent Intelligence	Global design-talent database, talent mapping, compensation intelligence, geographic mobility and customised hiring research.
Creative Outsourcing	Seasonal design, Key Look, trend and storytelling, CMF and global freelance design resources.

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Confidentiality note: This report contains aggregated and anonymized talent-market information. It should not be used to identify individual candidates without authorization.

Cover design: Original editorial artwork created for VS.talent's August 2026 Design Talent Report.